

BITLY

Sharing links on space-constrained sites like Twitter led to the rise of URL shorteners - tools that shorten links so they take up fewer characters. Probably the most well-known among these services is Bitly. (We here at Digit are huge fans of Bitly ourselves!) Apart from just shaving off a few characters off a link, Bitly has a plethora of features that allow you to use it as a link repository of sorts - use it as a cloud-based bookmarking system, an analytics tool or a social engagement monitor, all for no charge!



Use Custom Domain Names

You've probably noticed that the links in our magazine start with digit.in - this is Bitly's custom branding at work. What used to be a pro-only feature, custom-domains are now available to all users. Just create an account, head over to Settings > Advanced and configure your custom domain. Bear in mind though, that you need to be the owner/administrator of the custom domain that you're using, as you'll need to change the DNS/CNAME settings of your custom domain to point to bit.ly.



Customize Your Bitmarks

If setting up a custom domain seems like a lot of work, you can customize your Bitmarks (links saved with Bitly are called Bitmarks) by adding a meaningful word or phrase after bit.ly/ to make it easier to remember. What is usually just a random selection of letters and num-



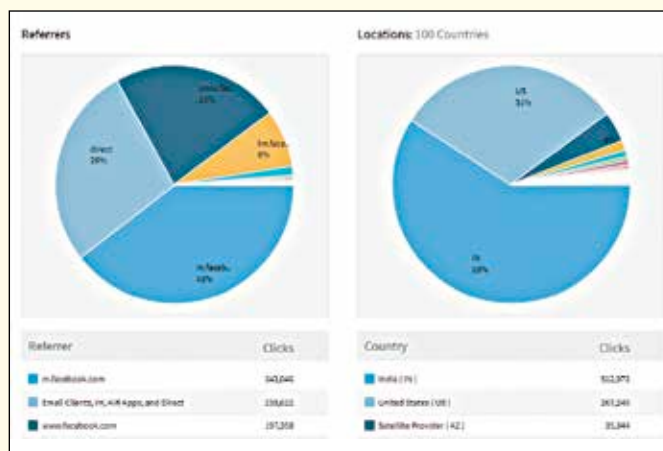
Click on the pencil icon to customize a Bitmark



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Tips & Tricks has its own page numbers, and does not follow the rest of the magazine's page numbers. This is done to ensure that you can cut out and save T&T in a separate folder for later reference.



The Stats page gives you details about your links' reach.

bers can now be customized by clicking on the little pencil icon next to a saved link, and entering your custom phrase.



Use it as an analytics tool

Bitly's great feature is that it gives you detailed analytics on every link you save using Bitly. You can view the number of clicks on your Bitmarks over time, which websites are driving traffic to your link and the countries this traffic is originating from. This is great if you want to analyze your brand's

reach on social media platforms - just shorten your links using Bitly before sharing them. Head over to the Stats section in the panel on the left to view your links' performance.



Using Bitly Bundles

One killer and underused feature of Bitly is the Bundle. A bundle is just a collection of links that can be shared using a single URL. It's great for aggregating a bunch of links on a particular topic for research, especially given that Bitly has lightning-

fast search that you can use to sift through your Bitmarks at a later time. You can also use it to create playlists with songs or videos from different sources (e.g. combining songs from Soundcloud, Grooveshark and YouTube) or a shopping list/wishlist with items from different e-Commerce sites. Bundles can also be collaboratively created - you can choose up to 12 people who can add links to your Bundles, and it's a great way to for teams to curate and share links.



Get stats on any Bitly link

Bitly gives you statistics on any link that's shortened using Bitly, not just the ones you've saved yourself. Just add a '+' to any link that's been shortened with Bitly (e.g. <http://digit.in/wvPing+>) and you'll get analytics for that link, including how many clicks to that page have been from your Bitmark and who has shared that page the most. It's useful if you want to check out the engagement on a competitor's website or see how a popular page has been performing.



Use the Chrome extension / iOS app

Bitly has a handy Chrome extension (<http://digit.in/BitlyChrome>) that lets you save the current webpage to your account with one click. You can directly save the link to Facebook/Twitter, customize it or even add it to a bundle from



Bitly for iOS saves Bitmarks and shows you trending links.